

Channel Playbook

Cymbal Voyages Brand Studio · Agency onboarding packet · Last updated September 2026

We use six channels and only six: paid search, paid social, organic, email, direct and affiliate. Briefs, reports and the Brand Studio agent use these names and no others, and we never name an ad platform or publisher by brand. For each channel this page states what it is for, the frequency caps, the creative norms and how it is measured. Attribution windows are 30 days post-click for paid channels and 7 days post-open for email unless a brief states otherwise, and a booking is counted only when the reservation is confirmed.

Paid search

What it is for: capturing demand that already exists. The always-on brand program (CMP-001) runs year-round at about \$4,000 a day and catches customers who have decided to book with us; category and destination terms carry intent-led campaigns such as New Year Ski (CMP-005) and Wave Season Cruises (CMP-007), our two most efficient search-led campaigns at ROIs of 2.9 and 2.4. Frequency caps: none by person; budgets are capped daily by market. Creative norms: functional and exact. Headline names the destination or category, the description carries the price frame ("from \$X per person, taxes and fees included") and one differentiator, usually curated packages or Compass points. No adjectives that would fail legal review; there is no room for them anyway. Measurement: cost per booking, ROI, impression share on brand terms, and the year-over-year trend in brand cost per booking, which has risen 9 percent as competitors bid on our name.

Paid social

What it is for: reaching a defined audience with imagery, and reminding people who have shown intent. It is the primary paid channel for retention campaigns (Winter Sun, CMP-003), for retargeting (Warm Escapes Retargeting, CMP-002) and for category launches (Fall City Breaks, CMP-012), and it carries video for adventure (CMP-008, our best engagement rate on paid social). Frequency caps: three impressions per person per seven days for matched and retargeting audiences, two per seven days for prospecting, and no more than two campaigns live against the same matched audience at once. Creative norms: visual first, copy as a caption of one line of context and one call to action. Beach-couple imagery and Plan your escape for lapsed members, city skyline for urban explorers, adventure footage for adventure seekers. Static and short video; no countdown overlays for Compass audiences. Measurement: click-through rate, cost per booking, ROI, match rate against the modeled figure, and unsubscribe or hide rate as a guardrail.

Organic

What it is for: being found and being trusted. Destination pages (60 of them, each 120 to 200 words with five concrete highlights), category collections and the seasonal warm-escapes content that starts each August. Frequency caps: none; publish on a calendar of two new or refreshed destination pages a week. Creative norms: the most specific writing we do. Each page says what the place feels like, what you do there and who it suits, names the season honestly (hurricane season, shoulder months) and carries no superlatives. Real place names are fine; real hotels, airlines and tour companies are never named. Measurement: organic sessions, destination-page conversion rate, and the share of bookings with an organic touch in the 30 days before booking.

Email

What it is for: the relationship. Email is our most personal channel and the one that carries loyalty. It is primary for member campaigns (Compass Anniversary, CMP-009, at an ROI of 8.5 on email alone) and it pairs with paid social for retention. Frequency caps:

no more than two marketing sends per week and one per day to any contact, counting every campaign together; transactional messages are excluded. A contact who does not open six consecutive sends moves to a monthly cadence. Creative norms: one idea per send, subject lines under 45 characters with no urgency words, the reader's situation in the first line, their points balance where relevant, and the loyalty points disclaimer in the footer whenever points are mentioned. "Welcome back" for lapsed members; never "we miss you" with an exclamation point. Measurement: open rate as a health check, click rate as the working metric (4 percent is good on a campaign opener), bookings within the 7-day post-open window, and unsubscribe rate held under 0.3 percent per send as a stop condition after the Spring Flash Sale.

Direct

What it is for: the site and app themselves, and the customers who come to us unprompted. Direct carries the home page collection, the Compass account page, search results, checkout and confirmations. Frequency caps: not applicable; the norm is one campaign banner on the home page at a time and no pop-ups. Creative norms: calm and useful. Prices shown per person with taxes and fees included before checkout. Confirmations state what was booked, what it cost and what happens next, with cross-sell only after the essentials. The offer running in email and paid social appears on the account page so a member who arrives on their own sees the same message. Measurement: conversion rate from search to booking, checkout abandonment, and the share of total bookings that arrive with no paid touch, which we watch as a measure of brand strength.

Affiliate

What it is for: reach among prospects through travel publishers, paid on booking. The Affiliate Partner Program (CMP-010) runs year-round at about \$1,200 a day in commissions and is predictable and low-risk, though its bookings skew to first-time customers who rarely join Compass. Frequency caps: none set by us; partners follow their own. Creative norms: partners write in their own voice. We supply the price frame, the required disclaimers, destination facts and the banned-phrase list, and partner copy that names us is reviewed before it goes live. Partners may not run paid search on our brand terms. Measurement: commissioned bookings, cost per booking, cancellation rate on partner bookings (higher than our average), and Compass enrollment rate among partner-referred customers, where we would like to do better.